

Two Ordinances

doc-two-ordinances

Sacraments · Number and Nature · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Christ instituted two ordinances for the Church (baptism and the Lord's Supper) that signify and seal the gospel.

In plain language

The original wording asks whether Christ set up exactly two ordinances for the church, baptism and the Lord's Supper, that signify and seal the gospel. The Greek behind the anchor verses supports part of this very clearly. In Matthew 28:19 the command to make disciples is carried out by the participle baptizing, using the verb immerse or dip (baptizo), into the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, and that verb runs across eight New Testament books, so baptism is plainly an ongoing act the risen Lord commands. At the table, in First Corinthians eleven verses twenty-four and twenty-five and in Luke twenty-two verse nineteen, the Lord takes bread and cup and says do this, using a present-tense command (poieo) meaning keep doing it, in remembrance of me, with the rare noun remembrance (anamnesis), which appears only four times in the whole canon. He ties the cup to the new covenant (kaine diatheke) in his blood, and First Corinthians eleven verse twenty-six says the eating and drinking proclaim (katangello) the Lord's death until he comes. So the words establish firmly that two distinct acts are commanded by the Lord and meant to be repeated, each with a physical sign. What the wording adds beyond this is harder to read off the text, and that is where readers genuinely diverge. First, the claim that these are the only two such acts, set against a count of seven, is a total none of the verses ever states, and the very same verb do (poieo) is also used by Jesus for foot-washing in John thirteen verse fifteen, though there it is a softer form (a subjunctive, meaning 'so-that you may do') inside a so-that clause and is called an example (hypodeigma) rather than a fixed command with bread and cup. Anointing the sick with oil (aleipho) is likewise commanded in James five verse fourteen, but by the elders rather than as a first-person institution of Christ. So whether the count is exactly two depends on how strictly you define an ordinance, and the words leave that line open. Second, the term seal (sphragizo) belongs lexically to a different verse, Ephesians one verse thirteen, where the Holy Spirit seals believers, not baptism or the cup. The lexical record clearly supports two instituted acts that proclaim Christ's death, but the exact count and the seal language are added layers rather than wordings the verses themselves carry, which is why the pattern is best read as contested at the level of its counting and sealing claims.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0218	ἀλείφω	aleiphō	to anoint	
G0364	ἀνάμνησις	anamnesis	remembrance	4
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	99
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	77

G1242	διαθήκη	diatheke	covenant	33
G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteō	to thank	
G2288	θάνατος	thanatos	death	
G2537	καινός	kainos	new	45
G2605	καταγγέλλω	katangello	to proclaim	18
G2806	κλάω	klaō	to break	
G3540	νόημα	noēma	mind/thought	
G3686	ὄνομα	onoma	name	
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidōmi	to deliver	
G4160	ποιέω	poieo	to do/make	568
G4221	ποτήριον	poterion	cup	34
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	
G4972	σφραγίζω	sphragizo	to seal	15
G5262	ὑπόδειγμα	hupodeigma	example	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Direct morphology (the grammatical form of the words) grounds the two instituted acts firmly. In Matthew 28:19 the command make-disciples (μαθητεύσατε), which is a completed-action command addressed to a group (aorist imperative, second person plural, V-AAM-2P), is carried out by the ongoing-action participle baptizing (βαπτίζοντες, present active participle, V-PAP-NPM), and the verb immerse or dip (βαπτίζω, baptizo) spreads across eight New Testament books as a continuing rite. At the table the Lord commands keep doing this (ποιεῖτε, present imperative, second person plural, V-PAM-2P), a standing command to keep performing the act, three times over bread and cup designated as his body and as the new covenant (καινὴ διαθήκη, kaine diatheke) in his blood (Luke 22:19, 1 Corinthians 11:24-25), and 1 Corinthians 11:26 says the eating and drinking proclaim (καταγγέλλετε, present indicative meaning ongoing simple statement of fact, second person plural, V-PAI-2P) his death. What the lexicon (the catalog of word meanings) does NOT supply is the exhaustive count: no anchor verse enumerates or caps the total of instituted acts, and the same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) attaches to foot-washing (John 13:15, ποιῆτε, subjunctive meaning a softer 'so-that you may do' form, in a purpose clause, framed as example or pattern, ὑπόδειγμα, hypodeigma), so whether the count is exactly two turns on the definition of an ordinance, which the vocabulary underdetermines. The seal term seal (σφραγίζω, sphragizo) in the lexical record attaches to the Holy Spirit, not to these rites. The verdict therefore remains disputed at the level of the counting and sealing claims while the two instituted acts stand on solid ground.

Scripture

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G3686 ὄνομα

Reasoning. Going therefore make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them into the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit (πορευθέντες οὖν μαθητεύσατε πάντα τὰ ἔθνη, βαπτίζοντες αὐτοὺς εἰς τὸ ὄνομα τοῦ πατρὸς καὶ τοῦ υἱοῦ καὶ τοῦ ἁγίου πνεύματος). The main verb make-disciples (μαθητεύσατε) is a completed-action command addressed to a group (aorist active imperative, second person plural, V-AAM-2P), and the means of making disciples is the ongoing-action participle baptizing (βαπτίζοντες, present active participle, V-PAP-NPM), baptizing them into the threefold name. The morphology (grammatical form) fixes baptism as an act the risen Lord directly commands his community to perform among all nations. The verb immerse or dip (βαπτίζω, baptizo) occurs across eight New Testament books (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, Acts, Romans, First Corinthians, Galatians), so the rite is a stable pan-New-Testament (spread across the whole New Testament) practice. The verse establishes one half of the proposition but says nothing about a total count of such acts.

1Cor.11.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0740 ἄρτος, G0364 ἀνάμνησις, G4160 ποιέω

Reasoning. Over the bread the Lord says This is my body which is for you. Keep doing this in remembrance of me (τοῦτό μοι ἐστὶν τὸ σῶμα τὸ ὑπὲρ ὑμῶν· τοῦτο ποιεῖτε εἰς τὴν ἐμὴν ἀνάμνησιν). The verb keep doing (ποιεῖτε) is a present active imperative second person plural (V-PAM-2P), a standing command to keep doing the act, governed by the preposition into or for (εἰς) plus the accusative (the direct-object grammatical form) noun remembrance (ἀνάμνησιν, anamnesis, N-ASF), a noun that occurs only four times in the whole canon. The present aspect (ongoing tense) plus the rare remembrance noun lexically establishes a commanded, repeatable act of remembrance instituted by the Lord at the table. This grounds the second instituted act of the proposition.

1Cor.11.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4221 ποτήριον, G1242 διαθήκη, G2537 καινός

Reasoning. In the same way also the cup after supper, saying, This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Keep doing this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me (ὡσαύτως καὶ τὸ ποτήριον μετὰ τὸ δεῖπνῆσαι λέγων· τοῦτο τὸ ποτήριον ἡ καινὴ διαθήκη ἐστὶν ἐν τῷ ἐμῷ αἵματι· τοῦτο ποιεῖτε, ὡς ἄκις ἐὰν πίνητε, εἰς τὴν ἐμὴν ἀνάμνησιν). The cup-saying pairs the adjective new (καινὴ, kaine, A-NSF, nominative meaning the subject grammatical form) with the noun covenant (διαθήκη, diatheke, N-NSF), the new covenant, and repeats the present imperative keep doing (ποιεῖτε, V-PAM-2P) bounded by the temporal clause as often as you drink (ὡς ἄκις ἐὰν πίνητε). The repeated dominical (Lord-given) command plus the covenant designation links the cup-rite to the new covenant in his blood and confirms its instituted, covenant-signifying character, while asserting no exclusive count.

1Cor.11.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2605 καταγγέλλω, G2288 θάνατος

Reasoning. For as often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes (ὡς ἄκις γὰρ ἐὰν ἐσθίητε τὸν ἄρτον τοῦτον καὶ τὸ ποτήριον πίνητε, τὸν θάνατον τοῦ κυρίου καταγγέλλετε, ἄχρι οὗ ἔλθῃ). The verb you proclaim (καταγγέλλετε) is a present active indicative (ongoing, simple statement of fact) second person plural (V-PAI-2P) and means proclaim or announce, making the eating and drinking a proclamation of the Lord's death until he comes. Lexically (in terms of word meaning) this is the closest support for the signify dimension of the proposition, since the rite proclaims the death, but proclaim (καταγγέλλω, katangelo) is a verb of announcing, not the technical pairing seal, so it supports signification while leaving the seal claim unattested.

Luke.22.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2806 κλάω, G0364 ανάμνησις, G4160 ποιέω

Reasoning. And having taken bread, having given thanks, he broke it and gave it to them, saying, This is my body which is given for you. Keep doing this in remembrance of me (και λαβὼν ἄρτον εὐχαριστήσας ἔκλασεν καὶ ἔδωκεν αὐτοῖς λέγων· τοῦτό ἐστιν τὸ σῶμά μου τὸ ὑπὲρ ὑμῶν διδόμενον· τοῦτο ποιεῖτε εἰς τὴν ἐμὴν ἀνάμνησιν). The Lukan account independently attests the same instituting words, with the present imperative keep doing (ποιεῖτε, V-PAM-2P) and the remembrance noun remembrance (ἀνάμνησιν, anamnesis, N-ASF, accusative meaning the direct-object grammatical form). Two independent witnesses, Luke and Paul, carrying the identical present-imperative command reinforce the dominical (Lord-given) origin and the repeatable character of the bread-rite.

John.13.15 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4160 ποιέω, G5262 υπόδειγμα

Reasoning. For I have given you an example, that just as I have done for you, you also should do (υπόδειγμα γὰρ ἔδωκα ὑμῖν ἵνα καθὼς ἐγὼ ἐποίησα ὑμῖν καὶ ὑμεῖς ποιῆτε). The foot-washing carries the same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) that grounds the Supper command, but here it is you may do (ποιῆτε, V-PAS-2P), a present subjunctive (a softer 'so-that you may do' form) inside a so-that (ἵνα) purpose clause, governed by the noun example or pattern (υπόδειγμα, hypodeigma, N-ASN, accusative meaning the direct-object grammatical form), and verse 14 adds the obligation you ought to wash (οφείλετε ... νίππειν). This complicates the exhaustive count, because lexically (in terms of word meaning) a do-as-I-did command does attach to a third act, yet it is framed grammatically as a subjunctive example rather than as the bare present imperative keep doing this (τοῦτο ποιεῖτε) with elements designated as his body and blood, so whether it ranks as an instituted ordinance is a definitional question the words do not settle.

Jas.5.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0218 ἀλείφω, G4336 προσεύχομαι

Reasoning. Is anyone among you sick? Let him call the elders of the church and let them pray over him, having anointed him with oil in the name of the Lord (ἀσθενεῖ τις ἐν ὑμῖν; προσκαλεσάσθω τοὺς πρεσβυτέρους τῆς ἐκκλησίας καὶ προσευξάσθωσαν ἐπ' αὐτὸν ἀλείψαντες αὐτὸν ἐλαίῳ ἐν τῷ ὀνόματι τοῦ κυρίου). The verbs are third person imperatives, let him call (προσκαλεσάσθω, V-ADM-3S) and let them pray (προσευξάσθωσαν, V-ADM-3P), with the aorist (completed past action) participle having anointed (ἀλείψαντες, aleipho), anointing with oil. This is an apostolic instruction to elders for a sick member, not a dominical (Lord-given) first-person institution with a sign-element designated for all believers, so it complicates the count without carrying the same instituting force as baptism and the table.

Eph.1.13 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4972 σφραγίζω

Reasoning. You were sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise (ἐσφραγίσθητε τῷ πνεύματι τῆς ἐπαγγελίας τῷ ἁγίῳ). The one verb that lexically (in terms of word meaning) carries the idea of sealing, seal (σφραγίζω, sphragizo), is here a completed-action passive form you were sealed (V-API-2P, aorist passive indicative second person plural) with the Holy Spirit as the sealing agent, not baptism or the cup. Across its fifteen New Testament occurrences (including Ephesians 4:30 and 2 Corinthians 1:22) seal (σφραγίζω, sphragizo) attaches to the Spirit, to authentication, or to closing up, never to the two instituted rites. This complicates the proposition because its term seal is not, in the lexical record (the catalog of word usages), predicated of these rites but of the Spirit, so the seal language in the stem reaches beyond what the anchor texts assign to the acts.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.11.23	Matt.26.26	tsk	1

1Cor.11.23	1Cor.15.3	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.11.27	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
1Cor.11.24	1Cor.5.7	tsk	1
1Cor.11.25	Luke.22.20	tsk	1
Luke.22.19	Ps.78.4	tsk	1
Luke.22.20	Exod.24.8	tsk	1
Matt.28.19	Acts.2.38	tsk	1
Matt.28.19	Matt.3.16	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.13.15 · addressed

Foot-washing is the strongest lexical competitor to the exhaustive count two, because it carries the same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) as the Supper command, here you may do (ποιήτε, V-PAS-2P, present subjunctive meaning a softer 'so-that you may do' form) in a so-that (ἵνα) purpose clause framed by example or pattern (ὑπόδειγμα, hypodeigma), plus the obligation you ought to wash (ὀφείλετε ... νίπτειν) in verse 14. This is addressed by observing the grammatical difference the words actually mark: the Supper has a bare present imperative keep doing this (τοῦτο ποιεῖτε) attached to bread and cup designated his body and the new covenant in his blood, whereas the foot-washing has a subjunctive (softer 'so-that you may do' form) do-as-I-did framed as an example, without designated sign-elements. The text therefore neither caps the count at two nor demonstrates that foot-washing is a third ordinance of the same instituting kind, so the count remains a definitional question the vocabulary underdetermines.

Jas.5.14 · addressed

Anointing of the sick uses third person imperatives, let him call and let them pray, with the aorist (completed past action) participle having anointed (ἀλείψαντες, aleipho), anointing with oil, in the name of the Lord. This is addressed by noting that the construction is an apostolic instruction to church elders for a sick individual, not a first person dominical (Lord-given) institution with a sign designated for the whole community and a standing command to repeat. The rite is real in the lexicon (catalog of word meanings) but does not carry the same instituting grammar as baptism and the table, so it bears on the count without settling it.

Eph.1.13 · addressed

The verb seal (σφραγίζω, sphragizo) attaches in the lexical record (the catalog of word usages) to the Holy Spirit sealing believers (Ephesians 1:13 and 4:30, 2 Corinthians 1:22), not to baptism or the cup. This is addressed by distinguishing the lexically (word-meaning) attested facts, that two acts are dominically (Lord-givenly) commanded and that the table proclaims the Lord's death, from the stem's seal predication, which the anchor texts do not place on these rites. The proposition is therefore not contradicted, but its seal language is judged an extension beyond the wording the verses supply, which contributes to the disputed verdict.

Matt.28.19 · unaddressed

The exclusivity claim, that baptism and the Supper are the ONLY two instituted acts set against a count of seven, cannot be settled from this verse or any anchor verse, because no anchor text enumerates or caps the total number of dominically (Lord-givenly) instituted rites. The figure two as an exhaustive count is an inference drawn from the threshold one adopts for institution (a first-person dominical command, with a designated physical sign, for all believers, to be repeated), not a number the lexicon (catalog of word meanings) states. The same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) governs foot-washing in John 13:15, so the threshold itself is what the words leave open. This remains unresolved because the counting claim is a second-order enumeration that lies outside what morphology (grammatical form), lexicon (word meanings), and cross-reference data can directly confirm or deny.

Concordance traversed

G0907, G4160, G0364, G1242, G2537, G0740, G4221, G2605, G2806, G2168, G3860, G4972, G3540, G3540A

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses are New Testament outside 3 John, so CBGM (a method of mapping manuscript relationships) data is not in scope for this run (not_in_ecm_scope, meaning not within the critical edition of New Testament textual variants). The well-known longer-versus-shorter question at Luke 22:19b-20 (the cup-saying bracketed in the SBLGNT, marked in the queried text by the editorial sigla around given for you ... poured out, τὸ ὑπὲρ ὑμῶν ... ἐκχυννόμενον) affects how much of the Lukan cup-saying is read, but even the shorter Lukan reading retains keep doing this in remembrance of me (τοῦτο ποιεῖτε εἰς τὴν ἐμὴν ἀνάμνησιν) over the bread, and 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 independently attests the same present-imperative command. The verdict that two acts are dominically (Lord-givenly) instituted holds across the plausible readings, so it is not variant sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. two-ordinance ecclesiology, expanded-sacramental enumeration, covenant_theology, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked

two-ordinance ecclesiology: affirms · On this reading an ordinance is a first-person dominical (Lord-given) command attached to a physical sign, given to the whole believing community, with a standing instruction to repeat. Only baptism (the present participle baptizing, βαπτίζοντες, baptizo, serving the imperative make-disciples, μαθητεύσατε, Matthew 28:19) and the table (the present imperative keep doing this, τοῦτο ποιεῖτε, over bread and cup designated his body and the new covenant in his blood, 1 Corinthians 11:24-25, Luke 22:19) meet all four marks in the anchor texts. Foot-washing has do or make (ποιέω, poieo) but in a subjunctive (softer 'so-that you may do' form) example clause, and anointing uses third-person imperatives in an apostolic instruction, so on this threshold the count of exactly two follows.

expanded-sacramental enumeration: disputed · On this reading the threshold for an instituted rite is lower, so that other dominically (Lord-givenly) or apostolically commanded acts with physical signs also qualify. The same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) governs the foot-washing command in John 13:15 (you may do, ποιήτε, with example or pattern, ὑπόδειγμα, hypodeigma, and the obligation you ought to wash, ὀφείλετε ... νίπτειν, in verse 14), anointing with oil is enjoined in James 5:14, and laying on of hands appears as a real practice (2 Timothy 1:6). Because the anchor lexicon (word-meaning catalog) neither enumerates nor caps the total, a reader who counts these as instituted rites is not contradicted by any verse, so the figure two cannot be lexically (in word-meaning terms) demonstrated as exhaustive from these texts alone.

The proposition compounds a lexically (word-meaning) attested fact (baptism and the table-rite are dominically, that is, Lord-givenly, instituted, both carry a standing command, and the table-rite proclaims the Lord's death) with two second-order claims the lexicon (catalog of word meanings) does not directly carry: an exhaustive count of exactly two, and the technical signify-and-seal pairing. The store confirms the instituting commands and their pan-New-Testament (spread across the whole New Testament) continuation (Matthew 28:19 to Acts 2:38; 1 Corinthians 11:24 to 11:27) but cannot adjudicate the enumeration, because no anchor verse states a total and the same verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) governs a third act in John 13:15.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The New Testament records Christ commanding baptism (Matthew 28:19) and a repeated bread-and-cup remembrance (Luke 22:19; 1 Corinthians 11:23-26); whether these are exactly two instituted acts and function to signify and seal the gospel, as against a larger enumerated count of instituted rites, is the question under test.

The stem embeds three loaded elements: the term ordinances as a fixed category, the exclusive count two framed against a count of seven, and the technical pairing signify and seal. The seal predication and the exhaustive number are theological enumerations rather than terms present in the anchor verses; the verb seal (σφραγίζω, sphragizo) attaches lexically (in word-meaning terms) to the Holy Spirit, not to these rites, and the verb do or make (ποιέω, poieo) governs a third commanded act in John 13:15 that the words do not rank against the table command. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized_form separates the lexically (word-meaning) attested instituting commands from the contested count and seal claims.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.28.19
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.11.24
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.13.15
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jas.5.14
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.13
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0907
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0364
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4972
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2605
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.28.19
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.22.20
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Luke.22.19

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved